

The Four Hundred Years Between the Testaments

Your Bible has a blank page between Malachi and Matthew. Empires rose and fell on that page, and the world Jesus walked into was built there.

ORIENTATION

The Page Most of Us Skip

Your Bible has a blank page between Malachi and Matthew. Most of us turn it without a thought. I did, for years. One prophet falls silent and a carpenter's son appears, and we assume the story simply paused. It did not pause. Four centuries passed on that page. Three empires rose and fell on that page.

When Malachi wrote, Judah was a small Persian province with a modest rebuilt temple. When Matthew opens, there are synagogues in every town, Pharisees teaching in them, a gleaming temple funded by a king named Herod, Roman soldiers in the streets, and a people straining toward a deliverer. None of that is explained in the text. The text assumes you know. The first readers did know. We are reading someone else's mail four hundred years late, and the honest response is to learn what they never had to be told.

HISTORY

From Persia to Alexander

Start with Persia. In 539 BC Cyrus took Babylon and let the exiles go home. The temple was rebuilt by 516 BC, smaller and plainer than Solomon's, and for two centuries the Jews lived as a quiet province of a tolerant empire. Ezra and Nehemiah belong to this period. So does the slow, deliberate work of becoming a people of the book.

Then came Alexander. By 332 BC the young Macedonian had swallowed the entire region, and though he died in 323 BC, his culture did not. Greek became the common tongue from Egypt to Persia. Gymnasiums, theaters, and philosophy followed the language. After Alexander's generals carved up his empire, Judea sat between two of the fragments, ruled first by the Ptolemies of Egypt and then, after 198 BC, by the Seleucids of Syria.

The pressure of those years can be put in one question. How Greek can a Jew become and still be a Jew? Some embraced the new world. Some resisted it. In Alexandria, Jews translated the Torah into Greek so their own children could read it. The question never went away. It is the question under half the New Testament.

CRISIS

The Abomination and the Revolt

In 167 BC the Seleucid king Antiochus IV, who styled himself Epiphanes, meaning God Manifest, decided to settle the question by force. He outlawed circumcision and Sabbath keeping, burned Torah scrolls, and erected a pagan altar in the Jerusalem temple, where swine were sacrificed. Jewish memory named it the abomination of desolation, the phrase Daniel uses and Jesus later picks up.

A priest named Mattathias refused to comply, and his son Judas, called Maccabeus, the hammer, led a guerrilla war that no one expected to succeed. It succeeded. In 164 BC the temple was cleansed and rededicated. Hanukkah celebrates that day. It is the Feast of Dedication that Jesus attends in John 10.

The revolt left more than a holiday. It left categories. Zeal for the law as a thing worth dying for. Martyrdom as testimony, told unforgettably in the story of the seven brothers in 2 Maccabees. And resurrection hope, sharpened by the question of what God owes the faithful dead. The world of the Gospels thinks in those categories because it bled for them.

POWER

From Hasmonean Kings to Roman Boots

Then the liberators became the establishment. It is one of the oldest stories in the world, and the church has lived it too. The Maccabees' descendants, the Hasmoneans, took the high priesthood and eventually the crown, two offices Israel's Scriptures had kept apart. They expanded the borders, forced conversions on conquered peoples, and fought one another for the throne with a ruthlessness their grandfathers had died resisting. It was in reaction to this dynasty that the parties of Jesus' day took shape. Pharisees calling the nation to holiness, Sadducees holding the temple and its power, Essenes walking out to the desert in disgust.

A Hasmonean civil war finally invited the wolf in. In 63 BC the Roman general Pompey entered Jerusalem and walked into the Holy of Holies, a desecration no Jew forgot. In 40 BC Rome named Herod, an Idumean strongman, king of the Jews, and by 37 BC he held Jerusalem. He ruled through fear, taxes, and breathtaking architecture, including a temple rebuilt on a scale Solomon never imagined. This is the Herod of Matthew 2, the kind of king who hears of a rival born in Bethlehem and reaches for a sword.

WHY IT MATTERS

The World Jesus Walked Into

Now read Matthew again. The synagogue where Jesus teaches was born in these centuries, a weekly gathering around Torah that needed no temple and no priest. The Pharisees he debates were the most respected renewal movement in the land. The messianic fervor around John the Baptist was not religious enthusiasm in general. It was four hundred years of occupation, desecration, revolt, and disappointment, pressed into a single question. When will God come back?

Even the gospel's reach was prepared in the silence. Greek, spread by Alexander, gave the church a common language. Roman roads, built by the occupier, carried Paul. The Scriptures, translated in Alexandria, were already waiting in every diaspora synagogue.

This is not trivia. A reader who skips from Malachi to Matthew will still meet Jesus. But he will not feel the weight of the question Jesus answers, and he will mistake the players for strangers. Context is not a ladder we climb to look down on other readers. It is a floor we kneel on. The four hundred years were not God's absence. They were the long setting of a table. We arrive late, and we should arrive humbled.

KEY TEXTS

Malachi 4:5-6

Daniel 11:31-32

John 10:22-23

SOURCES

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